

Code of Conduct

Document ID: POL-LEG-001 | Version: 4.0 | Effective: January 1, 2025 | Owner: Legal & People Operations

1. Our Commitment

Northwind Technologies is committed to maintaining a workplace built on integrity, respect, and accountability. This Code of Conduct sets the standards of behavior expected of every employee, contractor, officer, and director of Northwind. It applies in our offices, at client sites, at company events, and in any setting where you represent Northwind.

Acting in line with this Code is a condition of continued employment at Northwind. When in doubt about whether an action is consistent with this Code, ask your manager, People Operations, or Legal before proceeding.

2. Respect in the Workplace

Every Northwind employee is entitled to a workplace free from discrimination, harassment, and intimidation. Northwind does not tolerate discrimination on the basis of race, color, national origin, religion, sex, sexual orientation, gender identity or expression, age, disability, veteran status, marital status, pregnancy, genetic information, or any other protected characteristic.

Specific procedures for reporting and investigating harassment are described in the Anti-Harassment Policy (POL-HR-006).

3. Honesty and Integrity

Employees must be truthful and accurate in all business communications, both internal and external. This includes financial records, expense reports, performance reviews, marketing claims, and customer communications. Falsifying records or knowingly making misleading statements is grounds for immediate termination.

Employees who become aware of fraud, accounting irregularities, or material misstatements must report them immediately through the channels described in Section 12.

4. Conflicts of Interest

A conflict of interest exists when an employee's personal interests, relationships, or activities could interfere with their ability to act in Northwind's best interest. Employees must disclose actual or potential conflicts of interest to their manager and to Legal in writing.

Examples of situations that must be disclosed include:

- Outside employment, consulting, or board memberships
- Financial interest in a Northwind customer, vendor, partner, or competitor (other than ordinary holdings in publicly traded companies)

- Romantic or close family relationship with another Northwind employee within the same reporting line
- Direct or indirect personal benefit from a Northwind business decision

5. Use of Company Assets

Northwind assets — including funds, equipment, intellectual property, time, and facilities — must be used responsibly and primarily for legitimate business purposes. Limited personal use is acceptable provided it does not interfere with work or violate other policies (see POL-IT-001 for IT-specific rules).

Theft, misuse, or unauthorized removal of company property is grounds for termination and may be referred to law enforcement.

6. Confidential Information

Northwind's confidential information — including business plans, customer data, financial information, source code, and personnel records — must be protected. Employees must not disclose confidential information to anyone outside Northwind without explicit authorization, including after their employment ends.

Confidentiality obligations are detailed in the Information Security Policy (POL-SEC-001) and in the Employee Confidentiality Agreement signed at hire.

7. Insider Trading

Employees who possess material, non-public information about Northwind or about any company with whom Northwind does business must not trade in that company's securities. This restriction also applies to passing such information to family, friends, or associates ("tipping").

Northwind maintains trading windows and pre-clearance requirements for senior employees and those with regular access to material non-public information. The Insider Trading Policy (POL-LEG-002) provides full details.

8. Anti-Bribery and Anti-Corruption

Northwind employees must never offer, give, solicit, or accept bribes or improper payments in connection with Northwind business. This includes payments to government officials, customers, vendors, or other third parties.

Reasonable business entertainment and modest gifts may be acceptable; refer to POL-FIN-001 (Expense Reimbursement) and POL-FIN-002 (Procurement) for specific limits. When dealing with government officials, additional restrictions apply under the U.S. Foreign Corrupt Practices Act (FCPA) and similar laws.

9. Fair Competition

Northwind competes vigorously but fairly. Employees must not engage in anti-competitive behavior, including price-fixing, bid-rigging, or market allocation with competitors. Discussions with competitors about pricing, customers, territories, or sensitive business terms must be cleared with Legal in advance.

Information about competitors should be gathered through legitimate means — public sources, customer feedback, industry reports — never through misrepresentation or theft.

10. Substance Abuse

Northwind maintains a workplace free from the influence of illegal drugs and from the improper use of alcohol or prescription medication. Reporting to work under the influence is grounds for disciplinary action. Northwind provides confidential support through the Employee Assistance Program (EAP) for employees facing substance use challenges.

Alcohol may be served at approved company events. Employees who choose to consume alcohol at such events are expected to do so in moderation and to make safe transportation arrangements.

11. Environmental and Social Responsibility

Northwind is committed to operating responsibly with respect to the environment and to the communities in which we work. Employees should follow office recycling and energy conservation practices and should report any environmental concerns to facilities@northwind.example.

12. Reporting Concerns

Employees who become aware of violations of this Code, or of applicable laws or regulations, must report them promptly. Northwind provides multiple channels for raising concerns:

- Your manager
- Skip-level manager
- People Operations: people-ops@northwind.example
- Legal: legal@northwind.example
- Northwind Ethics Hotline: 1-800-NW-ETHICS (anonymous, 24/7, operated by a third party)
- Online reporting portal: ethics.northwind.example

Northwind does not tolerate retaliation against any employee who reports a concern in good faith. Retaliation is itself a serious violation of this Code and may result in termination.

13. Investigations and Discipline

Northwind investigates all reports of Code violations promptly and confidentially to the extent possible. Employees are required to cooperate with investigations. Failure to cooperate may itself be grounds for disciplinary action.

Violations of this Code may result in discipline up to and including termination of employment, depending on the nature and severity of the violation. Where appropriate, Northwind may also pursue legal action or refer matters to law enforcement.

14. Acknowledgment

All employees are required to read and acknowledge this Code of Conduct within 30 days of hire and annually thereafter. Acknowledgment is recorded in the Northwind compliance management system.